

Satio gets WVGA recording

Sony Ericsson's Satio gets video recording resolution up to 864 x 480 pixels with a firmware update. We've tested it this month – check our bazaar section

Map Loader on N900

Nokia's N900 internet tablet finally gets a map loader

Agent 001

hard to determine what one loves – the adage “there’s no accounting for taste” comes to mind.

That weekend I hopped aboard my bike and took a quick trip to a few cellphone shops around. Alpha, a well-known, perennially jam-packed shop selling handsets was first on my list. These guys sell stuff both with and without bills, the latter is something one refers to as a grey market purchase. The difference is, a bill nets you a warranty, while a product without bill generally does not. The exception being brands like Apple that provide warranty on IMEI numbers, not bills and receipts. Among other handsets I came across the LG KM900 Arena. We tested this phone last year; it’s got a very good interface, an ultra crisp 3.0-inch capacitive touch display and a really nice camera. The interface is also slick, and an obvious rip-off from the iPhone. I was surprised to find it available for as low as Rs. 17,500 – a very good deal for those looking at a multimedia phone.

Siddharth: the SMS junkie

The Nokia E72 was also on display, priced at Rs 17,900. This is a beautiful handset – very solid with a thick metal battery cover. The QWERTY keypad is surprisingly tactile and comfortable to use and will make sending mails a snap, while goodies like Wi-Fi, a five-megapixel camera and a 3.5mm audio jack ensure its universal appeal. Then I came across its older sister, the Nokia E75. This model is special because it has both a hardware number keypad and a QWERTY keypad that slides out from the side. This coupled with the metal battery cover and solid build make it a heavy phone. Despite the two keypads, the phone isn’t as sweet a deal as the E72 and I don’t recommend it. Why? – Because the QWERTY keys are flat, devoid of bevelling and lack tactility and the battery is a measly 1000 mAh, unlike the E72, that has a nice 1500 mAh battery. I also saw the Blackberry Curve 8900 priced at Rs. 18,500. The Curve is another sweet handset, although I feel Blackberry’s interface leaves a lot to be desired – their menus are so complicated. The keypad is excellent though

– superb for SMS junkies. Sony Ericsson’s XPERIA X1 is still available – a good handset, with speedy processing. The QWERTY keypad is a mixed deal – some like it, others don’t. It was priced attractively at Rs. 21,600. I felt the E72 would be a better deal and would be longer lasting. So I called up Siddharth, he wasn’t happy about the price, but relented.

Rossi: the Android addict

Finding an Android-based handset for a good price proved difficult. The HTC Hero was the only one that was available, priced at Rs. 23,000. When I asked the dealer about street prices i.e. without a bill, he said I would save 10 per cent but lose the warranty. After having a quick brunch at McDonalds, I walked into an outlet of The Mobile Store. They had the N97 Mini on display. Priced at just above Rs. 22,500 the N97 Mini is a pretty decent package, although having reviewed it I can say Nokia’s resistive touch-based interface sucks. Samsung’s B7320 OmniaPRO was also available for a mere 11,500 bucks – a decent price, but the lack of a touchscreen on a WM device is kind of pointless. The QWERTY keypad is pretty good though. The Nokia 5800 XpressMusic is another worthy priced at the 13,000-rupee mark; a decent touch phone, pretty compact and has good battery life – good for someone looking at a music phone with decent features, although the touch interface is laggy and not as intuitive as I’d like. There were a bevy of other Nokia N Series phones like the N79 and N86 available – none caught my fancy. Symbian as a platform is on its way out, and I recommend against investing in a high-end Symbian device. I couldn’t find an Android-based device for Rossi, although there were some other alternatives like the SE XPERIA X1 and X2 – both with QWERTY keypads, but he didn’t want another WM device.

Michael: The gadget freak

The HTC Touch HD2 caught my eye. I’ve never seen such a huge screen – this makes the device pretty big too, but it’s not unmanageably so. The HD2 is a sexy handset – WM 6.5, a capacitive touch interface and really snappy hardware under the hood. The touch interface works flawlessly, gestures, typing; everything has a nice feel and the large screen is a pleasure to behold and use. At Rs. 35,800, the Touch HD2 was right up Michael’s alley, but he told me that he didn’t want WM 6.5 and if he bought a WM device again, it would be WM 7-based. Well, I agree, although HTC uses a proprietary multi-touch UI, this is not as fluid or intuitive as an interface designed natively for a touch/gesture interface. One

handset that might fit the mould would be the yet unseen Sony Ericsson XPERIA X10. Based on Android 1.6, this handset promises a lot – a 4-inch touchscreen, good camera and music capabilities and a very fast processor. He told me he was waiting for this handset and WM 7 devices before taking the plunge.

I recommend people interested in buying a high-end handset in the range of 25,000 bucks do the same i.e. wait. The market is in a state of flux – capacitive touchscreens are taking over, and devices based on newer, more fluid interfaces will become available at more competitive prices. For me, the ideal touch device is one that doesn’t make me miss a hardware keypad, and in this regard, I’ve yet to come across such a device. WM 7 *should* answer a lot of queries as Microsoft has promised a complete overhaul and a completely new interface without the horrible Start menu system carried over from their PC OS. This year and the whole of 2011, should see an influx of newer, more powerful multimedia phones, we’re at the tip of the iceberg. 

